“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Ādi-līlā

Chapter 7

Śrī Pañca-tattva

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 Bowing down to Śrī Caitanya, the only refuge of the helpless, who grants the highest goal even to those whose aims are lowly, I now describe His magnanimity in giving loving devotion (*prema-bhakti*).

2 All glory, all glory to Mahāprabhu Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya! Whoever has taken shelter of His feet is truly blessed.

3 Earlier I offered obeisance to the six truths, beginning with the guru, and I have described the truth of the guru (*guru-tattva*). Now I shall consider the other five.

4 The five truths (Pañca-tattva) descended together with Śrī Caitanya, and with the Pañca-tattva He delights in the joy of congregational chanting (*saṅkīrtana*).

5 The Pañca-tattva is one substance; there is no difference among Them. Yet to relish *rasa*, this one truth appears in various distinct forms.

6 “I bow to Kṛṣṇa, who comprises the five truths: He appears in the form of a devotee and as the very nature of a devotee, as the avatāra of a devotee and as one known as a devotee, and as the energy of devotion.” (Śrī Rūpa Gosvāmī’s diary)

7 Kṛṣṇa is the original Lord Himself (*svayaṁ bhagavān*), the one Supreme Lord. He has no equal; He is the son of Nanda and the crown jewel of all who relish *rasa*.

8 He enjoys the *rāsa* dance and His other pastimes, and He is the lover of the young women of Vraja. All the others you see are His associates.

9 That same Kṛṣṇa has descended as Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya, and with Him have come those associates, every one of them blessed.

10 Caitanya, the Lord, alone is the truth of the Supreme Lord (*īśvara-tattva*). His pure body is filled with the mood of a devotee.

11 Kṛṣṇa's sweetness has one wonderful property: to relish Himself, Kṛṣṇa takes on the mood of a devotee.

12 Therefore Caitanya Gosāñi assumes the mood of a devotee, and His brother Nityānanda is the very nature of a devotee (*bhakta-svarūpa*).

13 Ācārya Gosāñi (Advaita) is His avatāra as a devotee (*bhakta-avatāra*). We all sing of these three truths as the Lord (*prabhu*).

14 One is Mahāprabhu, and the other two are Prabhus. The two Prabhus serve the feet of Mahāprabhu.

15 I regard these three truths as worshipable by all (*sarvārādhya*). The fourth, the truth of the devotee (*bhakta-tattva*), I know as the worshiper (*ārādhaka*).

16 Śrīvāsa and the countless millions of other devotees are counted within the truth of the pure devotee (*śuddha-bhakta*).

17 Gadādhara Paṇḍita and others are avatāras of the Lord's energy (*śakti*); they are counted as His intimate devotees (*antaraṅga-bhaktas*).

18–19 With them the Lord enjoys His eternal pastimes, and with them He spreads the *kīrtana*. With them He relishes love (*prema*), and with them He gives away the treasure of love.

20–21 Coming together to the earth, the five truths broke the seal of the ancient storehouse of love. Together the five plundered that love and relished it, and the more they drank, the more their thirst grew at every moment.

22 Making others drink it again and again, They became wild with joy. They danced, wept, laughed and sang as if intoxicated.

23 They made no distinction between the worthy and the unworthy, nor between proper and improper places. Whomever they found, wherever they found him, they gave him love.

24 Plundering, tasting and giving away, they emptied the storehouse. Yet this storehouse is wonderful: the love in it increases a hundredfold.

25 The flood of love surged up and spread in all directions, drowning women, the old, children and the young — everyone.

26 The good and the wicked, the lame, the dull-witted and the blind — all the people of the world were drowned in the flood of love.

27 The world was drowned, and the seed (of material existence) in the souls was destroyed. Seeing this, the five felt supreme joy.

28 The more the five poured down the rain of love, the higher the waters rose, until they covered the three worlds.

29–30 But the Māyāvādīs, those devoted to fruitive work (*karma*), the false logicians, the blasphemers, the unbelievers (*pāṣaṇḍīs*) and all the degraded scholars — every one of them, being very clever, ran away, and the flood could not touch them.

31–32 Seeing this, Mahāprabhu thought: “I tried to drown the whole world, but some have escaped, and My promise has been broken. To drown them too, I shall devise some playful stratagem.”

33 Saying this and pondering it in His mind, the Lord accepted the renounced order (*sannyāsa*).

34 For twenty-four years He remained in the householder order, and in His twenty-fifth year He took up the life of a renunciant (*yati*).

35 Having accepted *sannyāsa*, the Lord attracted all who had fled — the logicians and the rest.

36 The scholars, the unbelievers, the fruitive workers (*karmīs*), the blasphemers and all the others came and bowed down at the Lord's feet.

37 He forgave their offenses, and they drowned in the waters of love. Who can escape the Lord's great net of love?

38 The Lord is the avatāra of mercy, come to deliver everyone, and to deliver everyone He uses unlimited ingenuity.

39 Then He made His devotees of everyone, even the *mlecchas* (those outside Vedic culture). Only the Māyāvādīs of Kāśī escaped.

40 On His way to Vṛndāvana the Lord stayed in Kāśī (Vārāṇasī), and the Māyāvādīs began to criticize Him:

41 “Though He is a *sannyāsī*, He sings and dances. He does not hear Vedānta; He performs *saṅkīrtana*.

42 This foolish *sannyāsī* does not know His own duty (*dharma*). He has become a sentimentalist (*bhāvuka*) and wanders about with sentimentalists.”

43 Hearing all this, the Lord smiled within Himself. He ignored them and spoke to none of them.

44 Ignoring them, He went on to Mathurā, and after seeing Mathurā He came back again.

45 In Kāśī lived a scribe named Śrī Candraśekhara, a śūdra. The Lord, the independent Supreme Lord, stayed in his house.

46 He took His meals (*bhikṣā*) regularly at the house of Tapana Miśra, and He did not accept invitations to dine with the *sannyāsīs*.

47 Sanātana Gosāñi came and met Him there, and the Lord stayed for two months to instruct him.

48 He taught him the whole dharma of the Vaiṣṇavas and all the hidden meanings of the *Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam* and the other scriptures.

49 Meanwhile Candraśekhara and Tapana Miśra, deeply distressed, made an appeal at the Lord's feet:

50 “O Lord, how long must we hear You blasphemed? We cannot bear it; now we shall give up our lives.

51 All the *sannyāsīs* blaspheme You. We cannot bear to hear it; our hearts and ears are breaking.”

52 Hearing this, the Lord only smiled slightly. At that time a brāhmaṇa came to meet Him.

53 He came, clasped the Lord's feet and made a request: “I beg one thing of You. Be pleased with me and grant it.

54 I have invited all the *sannyāsīs*. If You come too, my heart's desire will be fulfilled.

55 I know that You do not go to gatherings of *sannyāsīs*, but please show me mercy and accept my invitation.”

56 The Lord smiled and accepted the invitation. He used this stratagem to show mercy to the *sannyāsīs*.

57 The brāhmaṇa knew that the Lord does not go to anyone's house, yet, inspired by the Lord Himself, he pressed Him earnestly.

58 The next day the Lord went to the brāhmaṇa's house and saw the *sannyāsīs* seated together.

59 He offered obeisance to them all and went to wash His feet. Having washed His feet, He sat down right there, in that place.

60 Sitting there, He revealed a little of His divine majesty (*aiśvarya*). His body blazed with great effulgence, shining like millions of suns.

61 His splendor captivated the minds of all the *sannyāsīs*, and they all rose from their seats.

62 The chief of the *sannyāsīs*, named Prakāśānanda, respectfully addressed the Lord:

63 “Come here, Gosāñi; listen, revered sir (*śrīpāda*). Why do You sit in an impure place? What is troubling You?”

64 The Lord said, “I belong to an inferior *sampradāya*. It is not fitting for Me to sit in your assembly.”

65 Prakāśānanda himself took Him by the hand and respectfully seated Him in the midst of the assembly.

66 He asked, “Your name is Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya, is it not? You are a disciple of Keśava Bhāratī, and so You are fortunate.

67 You are a *sannyāsī* of our *sampradāya*, and You live in this town. Why, then, do You not come to see us?

68 Though You are a *sannyāsī*, You dance and sing, and You perform *kīrtana* in the company of sentimentalists.

69 Studying Vedānta and meditation are the duties (*dharma*) of a *sannyāsī*. Why do You give these up and do what sentimentalists do?

70 By Your splendor You appear to us as Nārāyaṇa Himself. Why, then, do You behave so lowly? What is the reason?”

71 The Lord said, “Hear, revered sir, the reason for this. My guru saw that I was a fool and chastised Me.

72 He said: ‘You are a fool. You are not qualified to study Vedānta. Always chant the Kṛṣṇa mantra; this is the essence of all mantras.

73 By the Kṛṣṇa mantra You will be freed from the cycle of birth and death (*saṁsāra*), and by the name of Kṛṣṇa You will attain Kṛṣṇa's feet.

74 In the age of Kali there is no dharma other than the Holy Name. The Name is the essence of all mantras; this is the heart of the scriptures.'

75 Saying this, he taught Me a verse and told Me: 'Keep this verse at your throat and reflect on it.'

76 "The name of Hari, the name of Hari, only the name of Hari! In the age of Kali there is no other way, no other way, no other way." (Bṛhan-nāradīya Purāṇa 38.126)

77 Receiving this order, I chanted the Name constantly, and as I went on chanting, My mind became bewildered.

78 I could not stay composed, and I became mad. I laugh, I weep, I dance and sing as if intoxicated.

79 Then, regaining My composure, I reflected: 'Kṛṣṇa's name has covered My knowledge.

80 I have gone mad; there is no composure in My mind.' Thinking this, I submitted at the feet of My guru:

81 'What mantra have you given Me, Gosāñi? What power it has! By chanting and chanting it, I have gone mad.

82 It makes Me laugh, makes Me dance and makes Me weep.' Hearing this, My guru said to Me:

83 'This is the very nature of the great mantra (*mahā-mantra*) of Kṛṣṇa's name: whoever chants it awakens divine emotion (*bhāva*) for Kṛṣṇa.

84 Love (*prema*) directed to Kṛṣṇa is the supreme goal of human life (*puruṣārtha*). Before it the four goals of life are no more than straw.

85 The fifth goal of life is an ocean of the nectar of love's bliss; the bliss of Brahman and the like is not even a drop of it.

86 All the scriptures say that the fruit of Kṛṣṇa's name is love (*prema*). By good fortune that love has arisen in You.

87 By its very nature love stirs the mind and the body, and a longing arises to attain Kṛṣṇa's feet.

88 By the nature of love the devotee laughs, weeps and sings; maddened with love, he dances and runs here and there.

89–90 Perspiration, trembling, hair standing on end, tears, a choked voice, change of color, madness, despondency, composure, pride, joy and humility — through these many moods love makes the devotees dance and sets them floating in the ocean of Kṛṣṇa's nectarean bliss.

91 It is good that You have attained the supreme goal of life. Your love has made my own life fulfilled.

92 Dance, sing and perform *saṅkīrtana* with the devotees. Teach the name of Kṛṣṇa and deliver everyone.’

93 Saying this, he taught Me a verse, telling Me again and again: ‘This is the essence of the *Bhāgavatam*.’

94 “One who has taken this vow, chanting the name of his beloved Lord, develops deep attachment (*anurāga*). His heart melts, and he loudly laughs, weeps, cries out and sings; like a madman he dances, heedless of the world.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 11.2.40)

95 With firm faith in his words, I constantly perform *saṅkīrtana* of Kṛṣṇa's name.

96 That name of Kṛṣṇa sometimes makes Me sing and dance. I do not sing and dance by My own will.

97 Compared with the ocean of bliss one relishes in Kṛṣṇa's name, the bliss of Brahman is like water in a ditch.

98 “O guru of the world, I am immersed in the pure ocean of joy that comes from seeing You directly, and so all other happiness, even the bliss of Brahman, seems to me like the water in a calf's hoofprint.” (Hari-bhakti-sudhodaya 14.36)”

99 Hearing the Lord's sweet words, the *sannyāsīs* had a change of heart, and they spoke sweetly:

100 “All that You have said is true. Only one whose good fortune has dawned attains love for Kṛṣṇa.

101 You have devotion to Kṛṣṇa, and that pleases us all. But why do You not hear Vedānta? What fault is there in it?”

102 Hearing this, the Lord smiled and said, “If you will not take offense, I shall explain.”

103 Hearing this, all the *sannyāsīs* said, “We see You as Nārāyaṇa Himself.

104 Hearing Your words soothes our ears, and seeing Your sweetness soothes our eyes.

105 Your presence fills everyone's mind with joy. Your words can never be improper.”

106 The Lord said, “The *Vedānta-sūtra* is the word of the Supreme Lord, spoken by Śrī Nārāyaṇa in the form of Vyāsa.

107 Mistakes, illusion, the tendency to cheat and imperfect senses — none of these faults exist in the words of the Lord.

108 The truth that the *sūtras* teach together with the Upaniṣads is supremely great when taken in its primary, direct sense (*mukhya-vṛtti*).

109 But the commentary that the Ācārya (Śaṅkara) wrote by the secondary, indirect sense (*gauṇa-vṛtti*) ruins everything for those who hear it.

110 He is not at fault: by the order of the Lord he covered the primary meaning and put forward a secondary one.

111 In its primary sense the word ‘Brahman’ means Bhagavān, the Lord, who is full of spiritual majesty and has none above or equal to Him.

112 His powers and His body are all spiritual in form. Covering these spiritual powers, he calls Him ‘formless’ (*nirākāra*).

113 His body, His abode and His entourage are spiritual bliss, yet he calls them a transformation of material goodness (*sattva*).

114 He is not at fault, for he is a servant carrying out an order. But whoever listens to him is utterly ruined.

115 He regards the body of Viṣṇu as material, and there is no blasphemy of Viṣṇu greater than this.

116 The Lord is like a blazing fire, and the soul by nature is like a particle of a spark.

117 The soul is energy (*śakti*); Kṛṣṇa is the possessor of energy (*śaktimān*). The *Gītā*, the *Viṣṇu Purāṇa* and other scriptures are the evidence for this.

118 “This material nature is inferior. But know, O mighty-armed one, that beyond it I have another, superior energy, which consists of the souls (*jīvas*) and by which this world is sustained.” (Bhagavad-gītā 7.5)

119 “The energy of Viṣṇu is declared to be superior; the energy called the knower of the field (*kṣetrajña*) is likewise superior. The other, called ignorance and karma, is considered the third energy.” (Viṣṇu Purāṇa 6.7.61)

120 Taking the truth of the soul in this way and calling it the Supreme Truth, he covered the supreme greatness of the Lord.

121 Vyāsa's *sūtras* teach the doctrine of transformation (*pariṇāma-vāda*). But he (Śaṅkara) declared that Vyāsa was mistaken and raised a dispute.

122 He argued that by the doctrine of transformation the Lord would become subject to change, and on that ground he established the doctrine of illusion (*vivarta-vāda*).

123 In truth, the doctrine of transformation alone is the evidence. The proper place of illusion (*vivarta*) is the idea that the body is the self.

124 Śrī Bhagavān, who possesses inconceivable energy, by His will undergoes transformation in the form of the world.

125 Yet by that inconceivable energy He remains unchanged. As an example we take the material touchstone (*cintāmaṇi*).

126 Heaps of various jewels come from the touchstone, yet the gem itself remains unchanged in its nature.

127 If a material object has inconceivable power, what wonder is there in the inconceivable energy of the Lord?

128 The *praṇava* (*oṁ*) is the great statement (*mahā-vākya*), the root of the Vedas. The *praṇava* is the very form of the Lord, the abode of all the worlds.

129 The *praṇava* points to the Lord, the shelter of all, whereas the statement ‘*tat tvam asi*’ (“you are that”) is only one part of the Vedas.

130 Covering the *praṇava*, the true great statement, he set up ‘*tat tvam asi*’ as the great statement.

131 In all the Vedas and *sūtras* it is Kṛṣṇa who is named. But he gave up the primary meaning and explained them by indirect interpretation (*lakṣaṇā*).

132 The Vedas are self-evident (*svataḥ-pramāṇa*), the crown jewel of all evidence. Interpreting them indirectly destroys their self-evidence.

133 In this way, giving up the natural meaning of every *sūtra*, he explained a secondary meaning, inventing it all from his imagination.”

134 In this way the Lord pointed out the faults in the explanation of every *sūtra*, and the *sannyāsīs* were amazed to hear it.

135 All the *sannyāsīs* said, “Hear us, revered sir. There is no dispute about the meanings You have refuted.

136 We all know that these meanings are the Ācārya's own imagination. Only out of loyalty to our *sampradāya* do we accept them as the truth.

137 Explain the primary meaning, and let us see Your power." Then the Lord began to explain all the *sūtras* by their primary meaning:

138 "The greatest reality, which we call 'Brahman', is Śrī Bhagavān. He is full of six kinds of majesty (*aiśvarya*) and is the abode of the Supreme Truth.

139 In His own nature and majesty there is not a trace of māyā. Bhagavān is the object of relationship (*sambandha*) in all the Vedas.

140 If we call Him impersonal (*nirviśeṣa*) and do not accept His spiritual energy, we accept only half of His nature, and His completeness is lost.

141 The means we take up to attain Bhagavān is devotion (*bhakti*) that begins with hearing; it is what brings one to Kṛṣṇa.

142 All the Vedas call this the means (*abhidheya*). From devotion in practice (*sādhana-bhakti*) love (*prema*) awakens.

143 When one has deep attachment (*anurāga*) to Kṛṣṇa's feet, no attachment remains for anything but Kṛṣṇa.

144 That great treasure of love is the fifth goal of life. It lets one relish the *rasa* of Kṛṣṇa's sweetness.

145 By love Kṛṣṇa comes under the control of His devotee, and by love one attains the joyful *rasa* of serving Kṛṣṇa.

146 Relationship (*sambandha*), means (*abhidheya*) and goal (*prayojana*) — all the *sūtras* culminate in these three meanings."

147 Hearing this explanation of all the *sūtras*, the *sannyāsīs* humbly said:

148 “You are the embodiment of the Vedas, Nārāyaṇa Himself. Forgive us the offense of blaspheming You before.”

149 From then on the minds of the *sannyāsīs* were changed, and they constantly chanted the name, “Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa!”

150 In this way the Lord forgave their offenses and gave the name of Kṛṣṇa to them all as His mercy.

151 Then all the *sannyāsīs* took their meal with Mahāprabhu, seating Him in their midst.

152 After the meal Mahāprabhu returned to His residence. Such wonderful pastimes the beautiful Gaurāṅga performs!

153 Candraśekhara, Tapana Miśra and Sanātana heard and saw all this, and their hearts were filled with joy.

154 All the *sannyāsīs* came to see the Lord, and all Vārāṇasī praised Him.

155 Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya came to the city of Vārāṇasī, and the city and all its people were greatly blessed.

156 Hundreds of thousands of people came to see the Lord. A great crowd formed at His door, and no one could get in.

157 When the Lord went to see Viśveśvara (Śiva, the presiding deity of Kāśī), hundreds of thousands of people came and gathered there.

158 When He went to bathe on the bank of the Gaṅgā, there too all the people gathered in a great crowd.

159 Raising His arms, the Lord said, “Chant ‘Hari! Hari!’” And the people chanted the name of Hari until it filled heaven and earth.

160 Having delivered the people, the Lord wished to depart. He sent Śrī Sanātana to Vṛndāvana.

161 Hearing the tumult of the crowds night and day, the Lord left Vārāṇasī and came to Nīlācala (Jagannātha Purī).

162 I shall tell this pastime in detail later. Here I have told it briefly because the occasion arose.

163 Thus Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya, in the form of the Pañca-tattva, blessed the world by giving it the name of Kṛṣṇa and love for Him.

164 He sent Rūpa and Sanātana to Mathurā, and these two generals spread devotion (*bhakti*).

165 He sent Nityānanda Gosāñi to Gauḍa (Bengal), and there Nityānanda preached devotion far and wide, in every way.

166 He Himself went to South India and spread the name of Kṛṣṇa from village to village.

167 As far as Setubandha He preached devotion, and by giving love for Kṛṣṇa He delivered everyone.

168 Thus I have explained the Pañca-tattva. By hearing it, one comes to know the truth of Śrī Caitanya.

169 Śrī Caitanya, Nityānanda and Advaita, the three Lords, and Śrīvāsa, Gadādhara and all the other devotees —

170 at the lotus feet of them all I offer millions of obeisances. Somehow or other I tell something of Śrī Caitanya's pastimes.

171 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, tell the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.